2.2 Education and Land

Like most Americans, you probably consider the education you receive as your right, rather than a privilege. But to African Americans during Reconstruction, school was an important sign of their new freedom.

MAIN IDEA The Freedmen's Bureau made education available to African Americans in the South, but other aspects of their lives changed very little.

AMERICAN PLACES

Howard University
Washington, D.C.

General Oliver Otis Howard's dedication to education is still visible today. Howard University in Washington, D.C., is named after the first commissioner of the Freedmen's Bureau and was the first American university dedicated to the education of African Americans. Howard himself served as the university's president when it occupied just one building. Today, more than 10,000 students are enrolled at the large campus, taking classes in subjects ranging from law to medicine and education.



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AN OPPORTUNITY TO LEARN

African Americans appreciated the value of education. Slavery had denied many of them the opportunity to learn, so they saw education as a path to empowerment. **Literacy**, or the ability to read and write, and a solid working knowledge of mathematics gave African Americans the tools they needed to understand labor contracts. Education helped them advance in a **wage economy**, or an economy in which people are paid for their work. With a good education, they could fully participate in the political process and understand their civil rights.

The Freedmen's Bureau helped provide educational opportunities. The bureau and aid groups worked with individual communities to fund, build, and staff hundreds of Freedmen's Schools for African-American children and adults. These schools were often built on land owned by African Americans or housed in their churches. The schools were free, but since most African-American families counted on the labor or income their older children could provide, parents sacrificed a lot to send their children to school.

A shortage of teachers and space meant that schools often had to rotate students in three-hour groups. Typically, teachers worked all day teaching children and then held classes for adults at night. In some schools, however, young people worked and learned alongside adults in the classroom. In return, teachers experienced the satisfaction of teaching enthusiastic and motivated students. By the time the Freedmen's Bureau closed, about 150,000 students had attended classes.

BACK TO WORKING THE LAND

A good education was important to African Americans in the South because it offered their only chance for advancement. For the most part, uneducated African Americans worked the land of white landowners, but they faced discrimination in a southern economy on the edge of collapse. As a result, many former slaves wanted to obtain their own land to farm. Some freed African Americans had this wish fulfilled—at least for a short time.

In January 1865, General William T. Sherman issued Special Field Order No. 15, which set aside the Sea Islands for newly freed African Americans. The Sea Islands were located south of Charleston, South Carolina, and encompassed an area of approximately 400,000 acres. Each family would receive 40 acres to farm and a mule. News of the offer spread quickly, and about 40,000 African Americans rushed to settle on the land. But by the fall of 1865, President Andrew Johnson had overturned Sherman's order. The land was returned to the southern planters who had owned it before the Civil War.

With no land of their own, many African Americans went back to working for white landowners. At first, landowners insisted that the newly freed African Americans work in gangs, as they had under slavery. Over time, however, an agricultural system called **sharecropping** developed. In sharecropping, a farmer raised crops for a landowner in return for part of the money made from selling the crops. Some poor white families, devastated by the war, also took up sharecropping. But they did not face the discrimination that African Americans endured.

Sharecropping often left African-American families in debt to landowners. The sharecroppers needed supplies, such as tools and seeds, to work the land. Landowners would sell or rent the supplies to the sharecroppers on credit and at a high rate of interest. By the time the crops were harvested, sharecroppers had usually run up a large bill and, as a result, would receive very little of the profits from selling the crops. Sharecropping tied African Americans to a landowner's land and resulted in **black peonage**, a sort of economic slavery.

Unable to earn a living as sharecroppers or find other work, many African Americans began moving north or west. Some also fled to escape the terror generated by groups of white southerners.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the Freedmen's Bureau help educate former slaves?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What factors led to the development of sharecropping in the South?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** In what way did sharecropping replace slavery?

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